FDE COURSE · SESSION 01

Don't Build It Yet

FDE Mindset & Stakeholder Discovery

SCALER · SST

AISTUDIO

YOUR INSTRUCTOR



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Software Engineering × AI Engineering × Applied Problem Solving

WHY ARE WE DOING THIS COURSE?

From Classroom → FDE Sprint → Real Opportunity



Internship begins after successful completion of the sprint and AIStudio selection.

"Learn how FDEs work before being evaluated like one."

SCALER · SST AISTUDIO

DISCUSSION · 5 MIN

INCOMING CLIENT REQUEST

"Our sales team is inefficient.
We want an AI assistant to help reps close more deals."

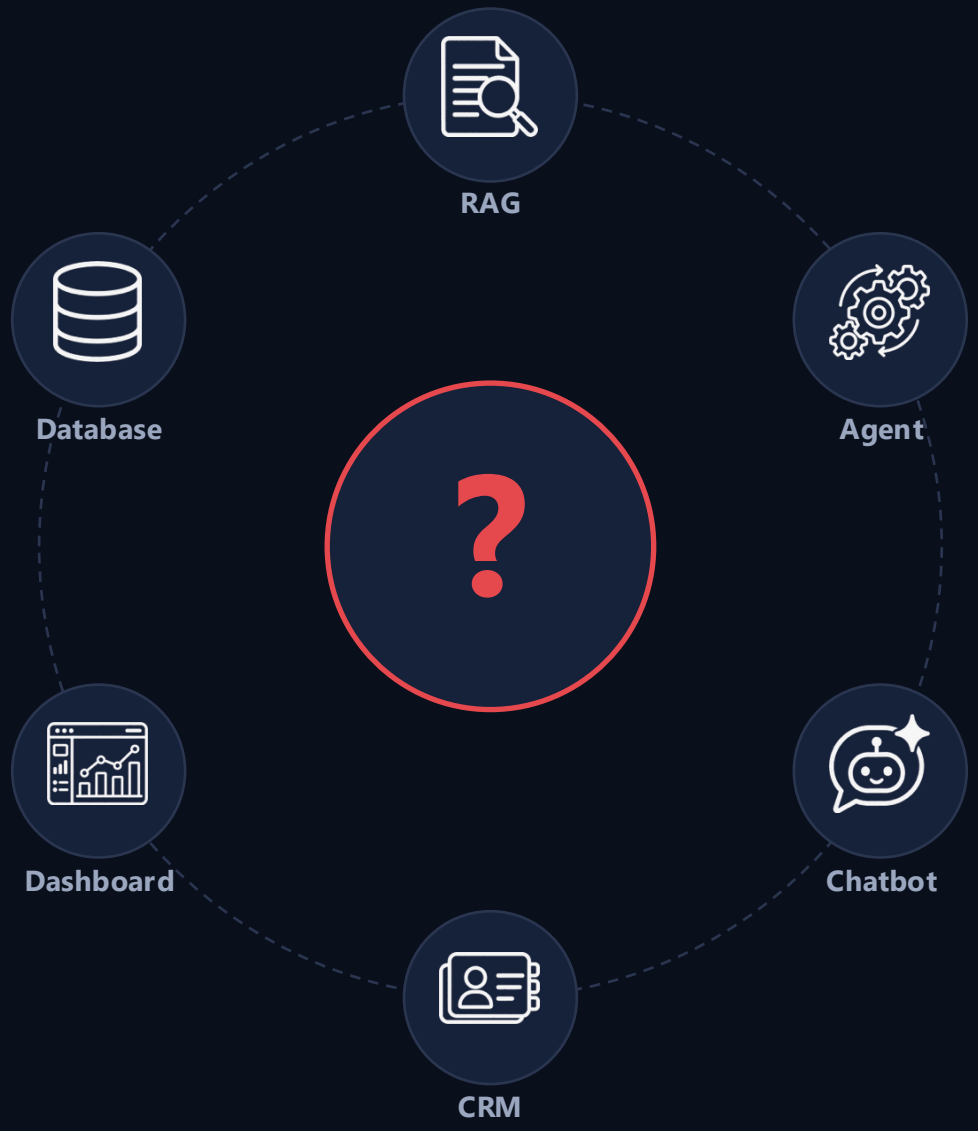
What would you build?

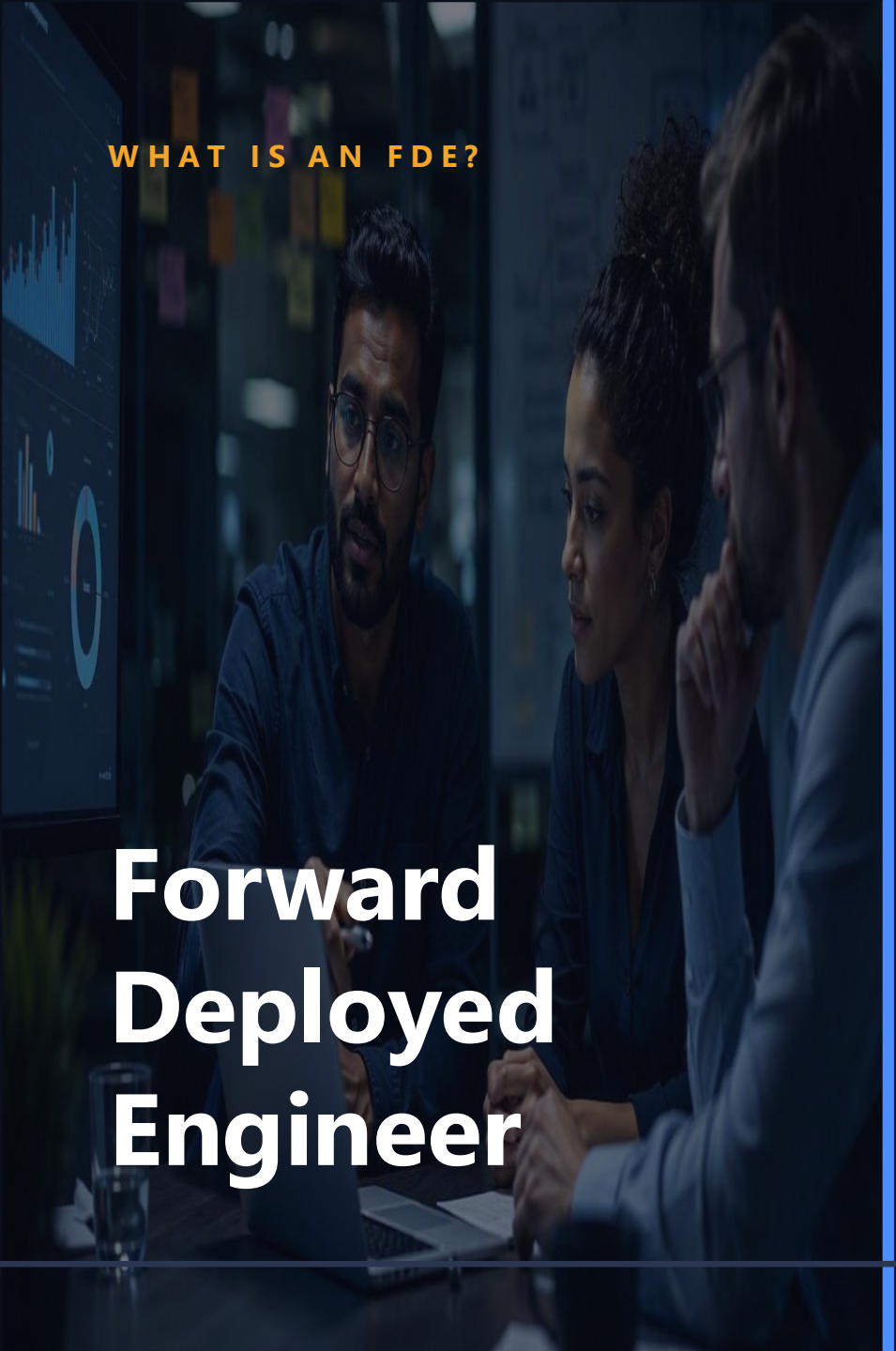
Take answers out loud. Write every suggestion on the board.

THE TRAP

We started designing before we understood the problem.

Every answer on the board was a solution.
None of them was a problem.





WHAT IS AN FDE?

Forward Deployed Engineer

Close to the customer.

Deep in the workflow.

Still ships code.

CUSTOMER ↔ FDE ↔ PRODUCT

The FDE sits inside the customer's world and still ships working software.

WHY DOESN'T IT FIT A NORMAL ORG CHART?

Three roles. One of them owns the outcome.

Software Engineer

Builds the product

Solutions Engineer

Explains / configures the product

THIS COURSE

Forward Deployed Engineer

Owns the customer outcome

WHY FDEs MATTER IN AI

Unique Data

+

Unique Workflow

+

Unique Constraints

↓

Generic Solution ≠ Enough

Someone has to bridge the gap.

The model is only one part. The real work is making it fit the customer's data, workflow and constraints.

THE FDE SKILL STACK

Six layers. Nobody is world-class at all six.



Engineering



AI



Communication



Product Judgment



Business Acumen

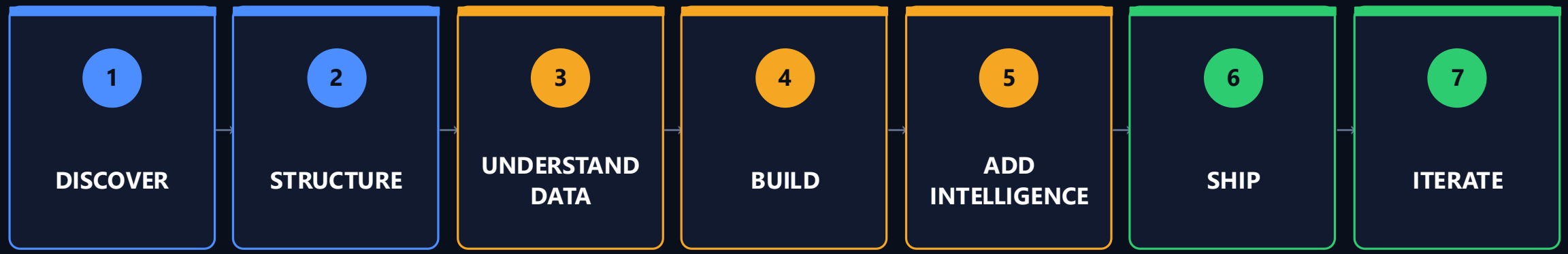


Domain Ramp

Breadth + Judgment

WHAT ARE WE GOING TO LEARN?

One engagement, end to end.



> **"This course simulates an FDE engagement."**

THE 15-CLASS FDE JOURNEY

Four phases. Fifteen classes.

PHASE 1 DISCOVER

- C1 Stakeholder Discovery
- C2 Workflow + Problem Structuring
- C3 KPI + Scope

YOU ARE HERE — C1

PHASE 2 DATA

- C4 Client Data
- C5 SQL + APIs + Files
- C6 Data Quality
- C7 Business Data Model
- C8 Dependable Pipeline

PHASE 3 BUILD + AI

- C9 Product Wireframe
- C10 Agentic Coding
- C11 End-to-End Build
- C12 AI Agents
- C13 Multi-Agent + Evaluation

PHASE 4 SHIP

- C14 Deploy + Observe
- C15 Client Review + Defence

TODAY'S MISSION

Find the problem before designing the solution.

THREE OUTPUTS YOU LEAVE WITH TODAY



Stakeholder Map



Interview Notes



Initial Problem Interpretation

REQUIREMENT RECEIVER

"Build an AI chatbot."

↓

"Which model?"

Optimises the request.

FORWARD DEPLOYED ENGINEER

"Build an AI chatbot."

↓

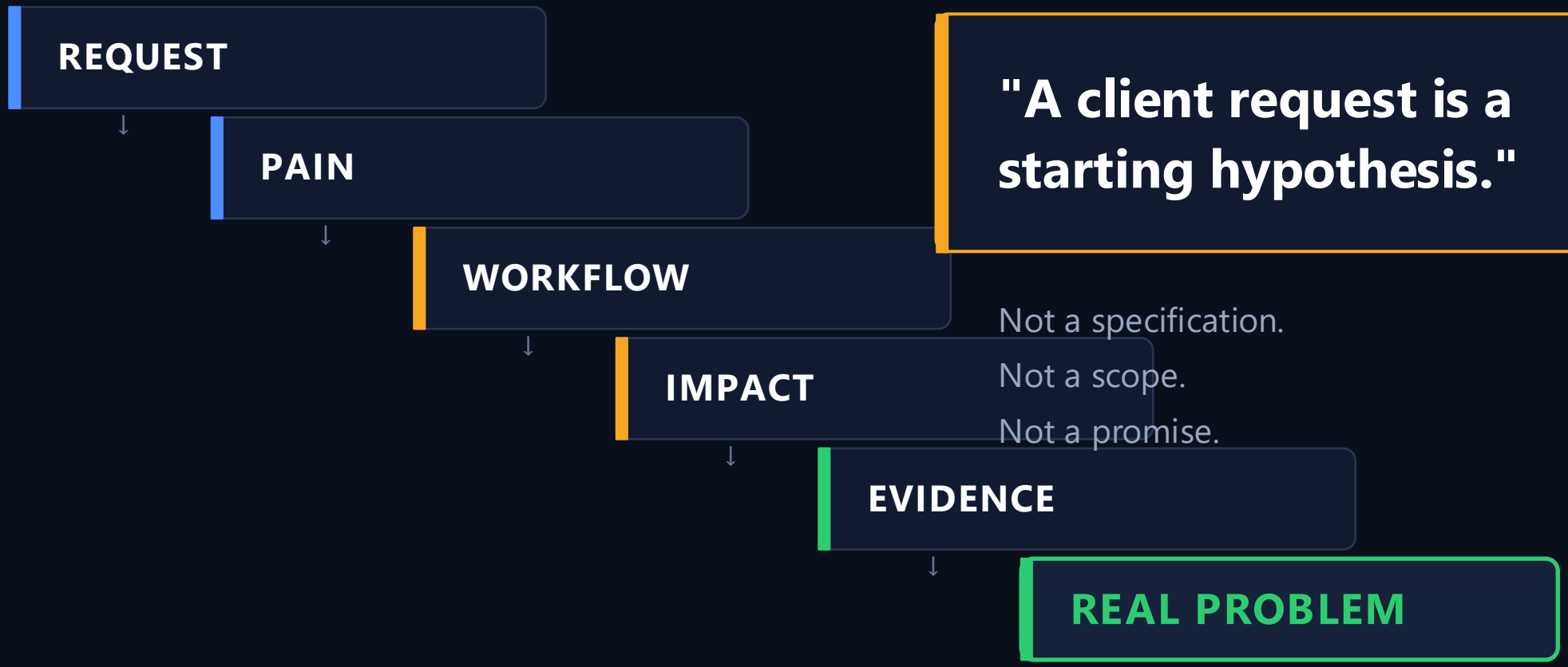
"What problem are we solving?"

Interrogates the request.

Same request. Two very different mindsets.

THE DISCOVERY LADDER

Every layer down is closer to the truth.



"A client request is a starting hypothesis."

Not a specification.
Not a scope.
Not a promise.

AMBIGUITY IS NOT A BUG

It's the job description.

01

Problem

What is actually broken?

02

Stakeholders

Who is affected, who decides?

03

Workflow

What really happens today?

04

Solution

What would change the outcome?

Evidence > Assumptions

WHO SHOULD YOU TALK TO?

Map the room before you ask a single question.



Different stakeholders hold different versions of the truth.

"Walk me through the last time this happened."

SIX THINGS EVERY INTERVIEW SHOULD SURFACE

1

Context

Who and what world

2

Workflow

Step by step, for real

3

Pain

Where it breaks

4

Frequency

How often it bites

5

Impact

What it costs

6

Evidence

How you'd prove it

ASK FOR REALITY, NOT THEORY

People describe the process they wish they had.

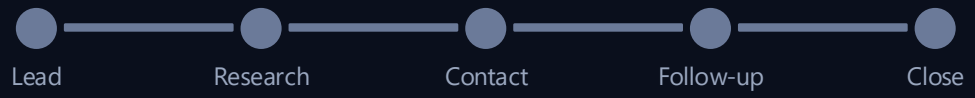
NO

"How does your process work?"

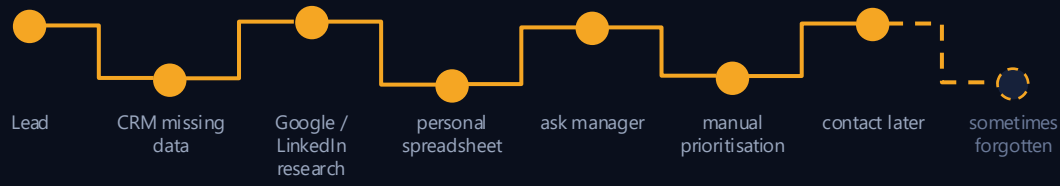
YES

"Show me what happened with the last customer."

CLAIMED WORKFLOW



ACTUAL WORKFLOW



Claimed workflow ≠ Actual workflow

CLASSROOM ACTIVITY · 20 MIN

YOU ARE THE FDE

Same client. Same sales request from Slide 4. Groups of three.

A FDE

Ask questions.

B Stakeholder

You have hidden context.

C Observer

Track what worked.

2 min	8 min	4 min	6 min
Set up roles	Discovery interview	Observer feedback	Class debrief / groups share

Discover. Don't pitch.

WHAT SHOULD YOU CAPTURE?

Your notes during the exercise.

01

FACTS

Verified / observed

02

ASSUMPTIONS

Believed, not proven

03

UNKNOWNS

Still need answers

04

STAKEHOLDERS

Who else matters?

05

PROBLEM INTERPRETATION

One-sentence current thesis

DEBRIEF

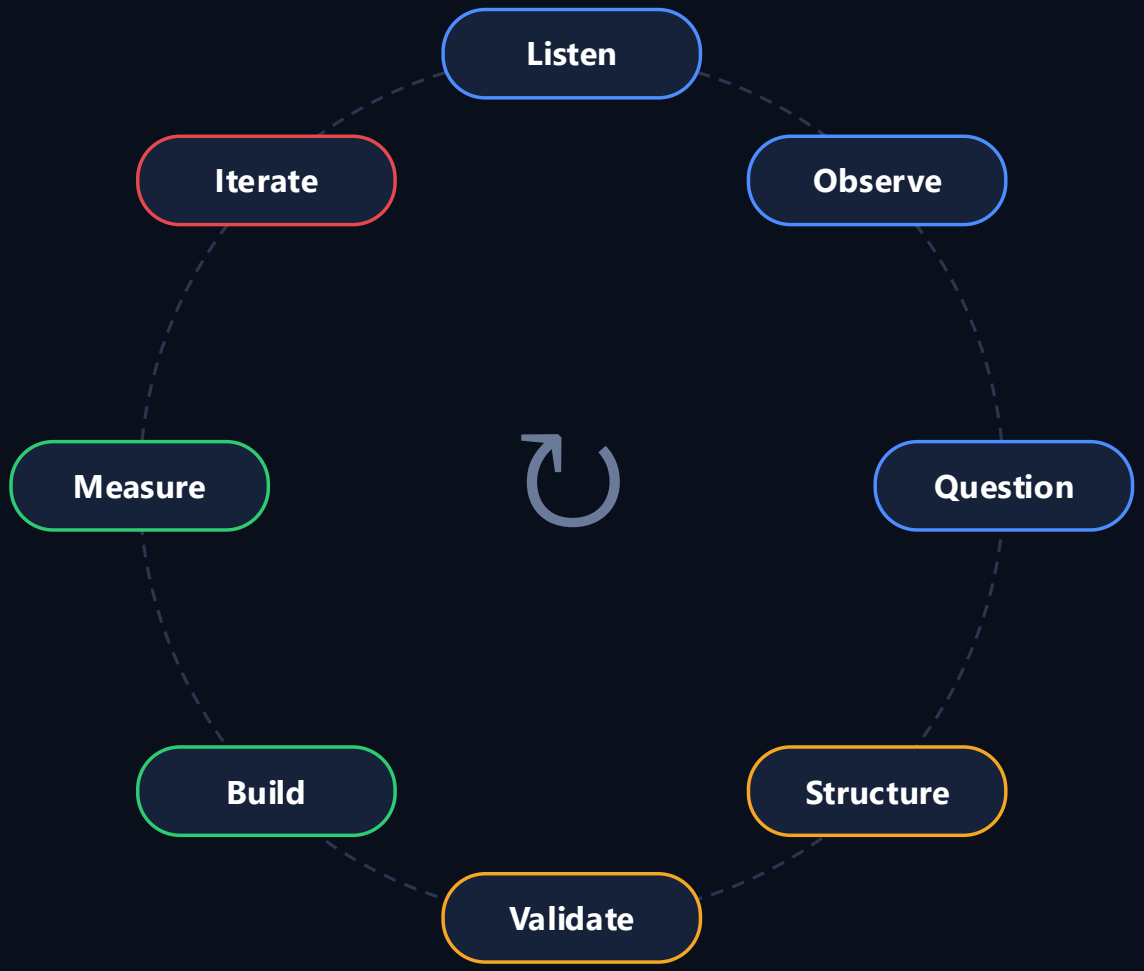
What actually changed in twenty minutes?

1. What did you think initially?
2. What changed?
3. Which question unlocked the most information?
4. Who would you speak to next?
5. Are you ready to build?

Not yet.

And that is the correct answer
at the end of Session 01.

THE FDE LOOP



DON'T BUILD THE REQUEST.

DISCOVER THE PROBLEM.